and blue. Her legs were watery and sapped of strength from a full day on her feet. But working with Josef was so much more fulfilling than assembly line work. Together, they were saving lives. And one day of hard work was nothing compared to what those nineteen women had gone through digging trenches for the Wehrmacht.

The world was a dark place but people could change that by bringing light. Josef had showed her how. Léa even had the notion that one day, after the war was over and she returned to France, she'd like to go to nursing school. She didn't mind the blood, syringes and waste pans—it was an incredible feeling to alleviate someone's pain and help them through a difficult situation.

Up ahead on the steps leading to the sick bay, she saw Maria, pacing frantically.

"Are you OK? Josef is—"

Maria opened her mouth, but only a small sob escaped her throat.

Léa could see from her red and swollen eyes that something terrible had happened. "What is it?"

"Ewa is dead."

"Oh no, Maria." She took her in her arms and held her close. "I'm sorry," Léa whispered. She stroked her back, a wave of despair hitting her. She wished she could have done more to protect Ewa, but the baby had been taken away. A few times she'd expressed her concern to Josef. He'd said it was out of their hands and it was impossible to save everyone.

"Come inside," Léa said, "tell me what happened."

"My baby starved to death," Maria said, backing away, eyes wild with panic.

"Is that what they told you?"

"They wouldn't tell me anything. They won't even allow me to see her." Her face crumpled, shattering like broken glass.

"I'm sorry."

"I should have—"

"Don't blame yourself. It's not your fault."

"It's all my fault. She was innocent. It was my duty to protect her." She looked away. "Maybe it was wrong to have brought her into the world."

"Don't say that."

"She suffered. Her life was all pain. It makes no sense."